Is This an Agent Problem?

Mode 1: Problem-Solving, Chapter 1/3 — Revision & Viva-Prep Cheatsheet (English + Roman Urdu)
Source: agentfactory.panaversity.org/docs/is-this-an-agent-problem

EN: A 3-Gates mental checklist that runs BEFORE you open any tool: which work should go to an agent, which shouldn't -- based on the nature of the task, not a tool's name. 'The cheapest mistake to fix is the one you catch before you start.'
Roman Urdu: 3-Gates mental checklist jo tool kholne se PEHLE chalti hai: kaunsa kaam agent ko dena chahiye, kaunsa nahi -- kaam ki nature dekh kar, tool ka naam nahi. 'Sabse sasti galti wahi hai jo shuru karne se pehle pakdi jaye.'

1. Gate 1 -- Does This Need an Agent At All?

- If a task can be described in one exact, always-the-same step -> a regular tool (spreadsheet, search, find-replace), not AI. Needing judgment/mixed file types/no existing app -> an AI job.
- If you just want an ANSWER (nothing of yours is touched) -> chatbot. If files/data must be ACTED on -> agent.

2. Gate 2 -- Once, or Every Week? (Mode 1 vs Mode 2)

- Mode 1 = solve it once and walk away. Mode 2 = build a permanent helper (Digital FTE) -- only worth it if the work keeps coming back.
- **3 Dials**, all must be high for Mode 2: how often, how similar the shape, whether it's worth it (time/items/error-cost/hassle).
- Rule: the third time you do the same task the same way, STOP and run Gate 2 -- don't wait for a feeling.

3. Gate 3 -- What Does 'Finished' Look Like?

- 3 lines before opening any tool: (1) works FROM (specific input), (2) want AT THE END (output shape), (3) done-check (testable in about a minute).
- Gate 3 decides the TARGET, not how to phrase a prompt -- a vague done-check like 'looks good' isn't testable.

Key Terms Cheatsheet

One line each — English + Roman Urdu.

Term	English	Roman Urdu
3 Gates	Gate 1: needs an agent at all? Gate 2: once or every week? Gate 3: what's 'finished'?	Gate 1: agent chahiye? Gate 2: ek dafa ya har hafte? Gate 3: 'finished' kaisa?
Answer vs Action	A chatbot gives an answer; an agent acts on your files/data.	Chatbot jawab deta; agent files/data par act karta.
3 Dials (Gate 2)	How often, how similar the shape, whether it's worth it.	Kitni baar, kitna same shape, worth it hai ya nahi.
Done-check	A testable confirmation that can be checked in about a minute.	Testable confirmation jo taqreeban ek minute mein check ho sake.

Quick Self-Check

Question	Answer
What's the rule-in-one-line this chapter opens with?	'The cheapest mistake to fix is the one you catch before you start' -- a mistake caught in planning is free, one caught after an hour of agent work isn't.
What's the key test in Gate 1 for 'chatbot' vs 'agent'?	Do you just want an answer (chatbot) or does something of yours need to be acted on (agent)?
What's the 'quiet, expensive mistake' this chapter warns about in Gate 2?	Keeping a Mode-2-worthy task manual forever -- it feels small each time but adds up to 20+ hours a year.
Why must a done-check be testable, not just 'looks good'?	A vague check can't actually confirm the work is correct -- a testable check can be verified in about a minute.

Where This Leads / Sources

Leads to: Problem Solving with General Agents, From One-Off to Worker. Full 3 practice exercises + research background in 05.

Source: docs/is-this-an-agent-problem/ (this repo), content originally via Zia Tutor AI connector.